Samarra

An asymmetrical rummyesque card game for two players

2 players | 30 minutes | Ages 12+

By Mark Goadrich – 2026

Version 0.4

There was once a **Merchant** selling their wares in the Baghdad market. The **Merchant** looked up and saw **Death** across the square, pointing menacingly at them. Scared for their life, the **Merchant** packed up and fled quickly across the desert to Samarra. In the middle of the night, they awoke to find **Death** at the foot of their bed. The **Merchant** asked "Why did you make a threatening gesture at me this morning?" "Sorry I scared you," **Death** said, "I was just astonished to see you in Baghdad, for I had an appointment tonight with you in Samarra."

Paraphrased from a retelling of an ancient tale.[1]

[1]https://subsublibrarian.com/2022/04/13/the-history-of-the-epigraph-from-appointment-in-samarra/

Overview

In Samarra, players take on the roles of **Death** and the **Merchant**. **Death** attempts to manipulate the fate of the **Merchant** through careful card management. Will the **Merchant** survive and escape their appointment with **Death**? Samarra is played twice, with points totaled across both games. In the second game players will swap the roles of **Death** and the **Merchant**.

Components: 48 Cards

- 2 each of 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10 in four suits.
- ***Suit*** denotes one of four locations: Samarra, Baghdad, Mosul, Tikrit.
- ***Value*** denotes an item to be sold.

Note: A Samarra deck can be constructed by selecting the appropriate cards from two standard 52-card decks with identical backs.

Rules

One player is **Death**, and the other the **Merchant.**

Setup

- Shuffle the deck and deal each player 8 cards, to be kept privately..
- Place one card from the deck ***face-down*** for **Death**'s location.
- Place one card from the deck ***face-up*** for the **Merchant**'s location.

How To Play

Each game consists of ***9 rounds***. In each round, **Death** and the **Merchant** each take a turn, followed by a Reckoning. **Death** goes first.

Death

Death earns points for cursing sets of items.

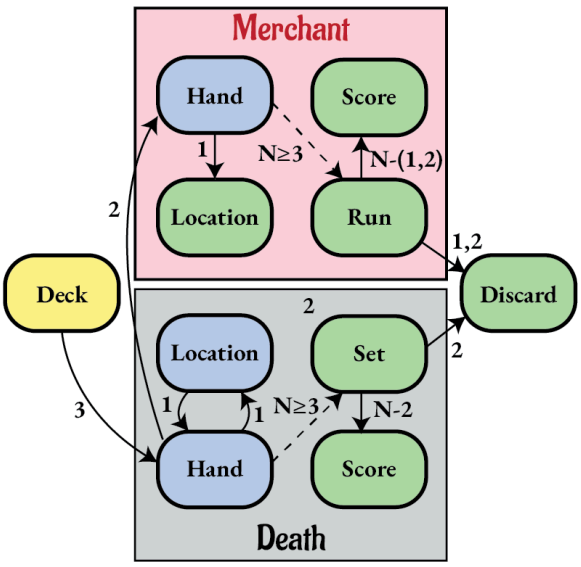
1. Draw 3 cards from the deck
2. Pick up **Death**'s location card.
3. *Optional:* Play at least 3 cards that form a ***set*** (9, 9, 9, etc).
    a. Must have ***3 cards remaining*** in their hand after playing a set.
    b. **Discard 2** cards from the set, and add the remaining cards to **Death**'s score pile.
4. Play 1 card face-down to become **Death**'s new location.
5. Give 2 cards to the **Merchant**.

Merchant

The **Merchant** earns points by selling items.

1. Take the 2 cards offered from **Death**.
2. *Optional:* Play at least 3 cards that form a ***run*** (6, 7, 8, etc) in ***one suit***.
    a. Must have ***1 card remaining*** in their hand after playing a run.
    b. If the run ***matches their location's suit***, only ***discard 1*** run card, otherwise ***discard 2*** run cards, add the remaining cards to the **Merchant**'s score pile.
3. The **Merchant** plays a location card, keeping the location cards *splayed* so the number of rounds can be easily counted.

One Round



Reckoning with Death

Does the ***suit*** of the **Merchant**'s location match the ***suit*** of **Death**'s location card?

- YES: **Death** reveals their location and scares the **Merchant**!
- Is this the ***third time*** the **Merchant** has been scared?
    - YES**: Death *wins instantly*!**
    - NO: Add the top card of the deck face-up to **Death**'s score pile.

Game End

The game is over when either the **Merchant** plays their ***ninth location*** card (*tenth card in location splay*) with a final Reckoning, or **Death** has thrice scared the **Merchant**.

Each player counts the number of cards in their score pile, and records their total. ***In an instant win,* Death *instead scores 15 points***.

Swap Roles

For the second game, players swap roles between **Death** and the **Merchant,** shuffle all the cards, and play again.

Final Tally

After the second swapped game, players total up their points from both games to determine the winner.

If there is a tie, then both players share the win together.

Acknowledgements

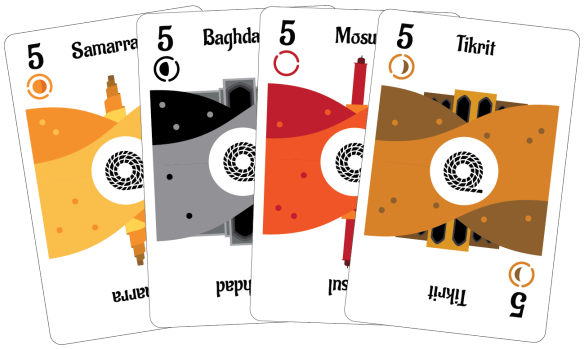
Thank you to my playtesters, Ryan, Greg, Brad, Gina, Dave, and James, for extremely helpful observations and suggestions.

Logo derived from
https://www.svgrepo.com/svg/229503/desert
Icons from the Noun Project, by Amethyst Studio, Adeel rehman, Harianto, Kosong Tujuh, Lucas Helle, and Graphic Nehar.
Fonts used
Aladin
https://fonts.google.com/specimen/Aladin
Spectral
https://fonts.google.com/specimen/Spectral

The cards depict four historical landmarks found in Iraq which date back to the 12th century: The Great Mosque of Samarra, The Great Mosque of al-Nuri in Mosul, The Green Church in Tikrit, and The Abbasid Palace in Baghdad.

Version History

0.1 Initial ideas while driving in Grand Canyon
0.2 Added more cards to open player options
0.3 Moved Reckoning to every day
0.4 Smoothed out turn order





Goodpoch GAMES